

Mauritania

 The northern two-thirds of Mauritania are desert. The only farmland lies in a narrow, fertile strip along the bank of the River Senegal in the southwest. This area is scattered with small villages and oases. Nomadic Moors of Arab descent, from the north, live in Mauritania. They have often clashed with black farmers in the south.



Fishing

The waters off Mauritania are said to have the richest fish stocks in the world; they attract many foreign fishing fleets. All catches must be sold through the state fishing company. Fishing provides more than half of Mauritania's export earnings.

Desertification

Successive years of drought and overgrazing in the Sahel region have caused the desert to expand southwards, killing livestock and forcing many nomads to move into towns.

Government schemes are attempting to reclaim the land by reducing soil erosion.

MAURITANIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Nouakchott

AREA 1,025,520 sq km
(395,953 sq miles)

POPULATION 2,700,000

MAIN LANGUAGES Arabic, French,
Hassaniya, Wolof, Soninké

MAJOR RELIGION Muslim

CURRENCY Ouguiya

Gypsum crystal

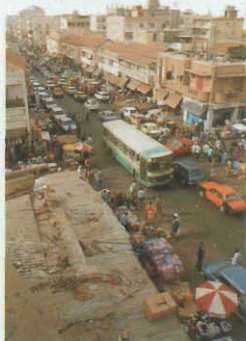


Mineral wealth

The Mauritanian desert contains the largest deposits of gypsum – used for making plaster – and some of the largest reserves of iron ore in the world. The country also exports gold. A single rail line connects mines with Nouakchott, the country's capital and main port.

Senegal

 The flat, semi-desert plains of Senegal are crossed by four rivers – the Senegal, Gambia, Saloum, and Casamance – which provide water for agriculture, the country's main source of income. Tourism is also developing. Senegal has a mix of ethnic groups, the largest of which are the Wolofs.



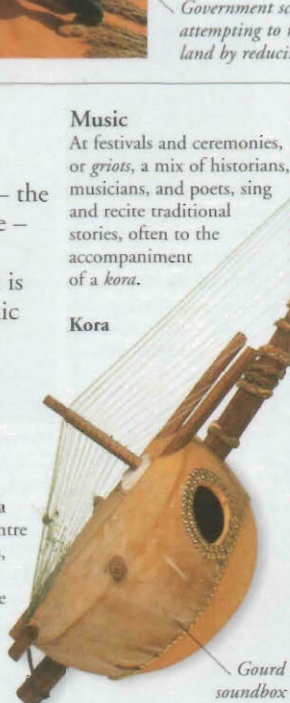
Dakar

Senegal's capital and major port, Dakar is a bustling industrial centre with good restaurants, shops, and markets. However, many of the 2,500,000 people who live here are poor and live in suburban slums.

Music

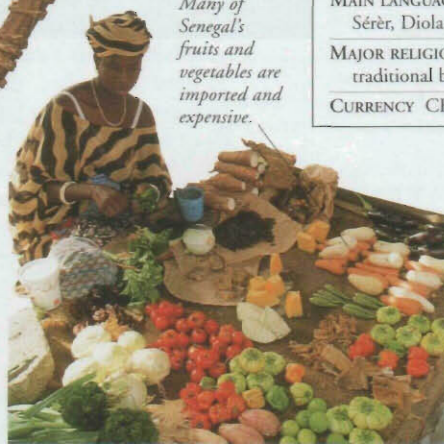
At festivals and ceremonies, or *griots*, a mix of historians, musicians, and poets, sing and recite traditional stories, often to the accompaniment of a *kora*.

Kora



Musicians pluck the 21 strings to give a wide range of muted sounds.

Many of Senegal's fruits and vegetables are imported and expensive.



SENEGAL FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Dakar

AREA 192,530 sq km (74,336 sq miles)

POPULATION 9,500,000

MAIN LANGUAGES French, Wolof, Fulani,
Sérér, Diola, Mandinka

MAJOR RELIGIONS Muslim, Christian,
traditional beliefs

CURRENCY CFA franc

Farming

About 60 per cent of the Senegalese labour force works on the land growing cotton and sugar-cane for export, and rice, sorghum, and millet for their food. Until droughts in the 1970s damaged yields, groundnuts were the main cash crop. Fish is now the main export.

Gambia

 One of the most densely populated countries in Africa, Gambia occupies a narrow strip either side of the River Gambia and is surrounded on three sides by Senegal. With little industry, 80 per cent of the people live off the land. Groundnuts make up 80 per cent of exports. The main ethnic groups are the Mandingo, Fulani, and Wolof.



GAMBIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Banjul

AREA 10,000 sq km
(3,861 sq miles)

POPULATION 1,300,000

MAIN LANGUAGES English, Mandinka

MAJOR RELIGIONS Muslim, Christian,
traditional beliefs

CURRENCY Dalasi

Tourism

Gambia is an attractive destination for winter sun-seekers from Europe. Tourism, the country's fastest-growing industry, employs one in ten Gambians. About 10,000 of those work on a seasonal basis.

Guinea-Bissau

 Rainfall in Guinea-Bissau is more reliable than in most of the rest of Africa, enabling the country to be self-sufficient in rice. However, flooding is common along the coast because farmers have cut down mangroves to plant rice fields. Most people travel by boat.

Cashew nuts



Grated coconut



Coconut

GUINEA-BISSAU FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Bissau

AREA 28,120 sq km
(10,857 sq miles)

POPULATION 1,096,000

MAIN LANGUAGES Portuguese, Crioulo

MAJOR RELIGIONS Traditional beliefs,
Muslim, Christian

CURRENCY Peso

Cashew nuts

Farming employs 85 per cent of the work-force. Rice, cotton, groundnuts, and copra are produced as cash crops, as are cashew nuts, which make up nearly 60 per cent of the country's exports.